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From Malaria Drug to Anticancer Agent: A Five-Year Review of Artemisinin's Evolving Role in Oncology (2021-2026

Molecular Mechanisms of Action: The Dominance of Ferroptosis and Beyond

The investigation into artemisinin and its derivatives as anticancer agents has matured significantly over the past five years, shifting from broad observations of cytotoxicity to a deeply nuanced understanding of their specific molecular mechanisms. While the foundational principle of iron-dependent activation remains central, recent research has firmly established iron-dependent programmed cell death, or ferroptosis, as the dominant pathway through which these compounds exert their selective toxicity against malignant cells [2] [3]. This mechanistic clarity provides a robust framework for rationalizing therapeutic applications and designing novel strategies to enhance their efficacy. The sesquiterpene lactone core of artemisinin, particularly its essential 1,2,4-trioxane pharmacophore containing an endoperoxide bridge, is the chemical basis for all its biological activities [2] [6]. This peroxide bridge is activated upon interaction with intracellular iron species, primarily heme or free ferrous iron (Fe^{2+}), leading to its cleavage and the generation of cytotoxic carbon-centered free radicals and a subsequent surge of reactive oxygen species (ROS) [10] [14] [21]. This oxidative burst is the initial trigger for a cascade of downstream cellular damage that culminates in multiple forms of regulated cell death.

The induction of ferroptosis represents a paradigm shift in understanding artemisinin's action. Unlike classical apoptosis, ferroptosis is characterized by the iron-dependent accumulation of lethal levels of lipid peroxides on cellular membranes, leading to membrane rupture and cell death [2] [3]. Artemisinins are potent inducers of this pathway, acting at several critical junctures. A primary mechanism involves the disruption of intracellular iron homeostasis. Studies have shown that artemisinins promote the lysosomal degradation of ferritin, the principal protein responsible for storing intracellular iron [2] [3]. This process, termed ferritinophagy, results in the release of a large pool of free iron into the cytosol [2] [6]. The sudden increase in labile iron fuels the Fenton reaction, a chemical process where Fe^{2+} catalyzes the conversion of less

reactive hydrogen peroxide into highly destructive hydroxyl radicals [2]. These radicals initiate and propagate the peroxidation of polyunsaturated fatty acids within cellular membranes, causing catastrophic oxidative damage [2] [3].

Crucially, artemisinins simultaneously disarm the cell's primary defense system against lipid peroxidation. The glutathione peroxidase 4 (GPX4) enzyme, often referred to as the guardian of ferroptosis, relies on glutathione (GSH) to neutralize lipid hydroperoxides and repair membrane damage [2]. Artemisinins can downregulate the system Xc- transporter, which imports cystine for GSH synthesis, and directly inhibit GPX4 activity [2] [4]. By crippling this antioxidant axis, artemisinins push the cell beyond its capacity to manage oxidative stress, sealing its fate through ferroptosis [2] [7]. This dual action—flooding the cell with pro-oxidant iron while disabling its anti-oxidant machinery—is a hallmark of artemisinin's ferroptotic mechanism. The sensitivity of cancer cells to this process is often heightened due to their "iron addiction," a state of elevated intracellular iron required for rapid proliferation, making them more vulnerable than normal cells [9] [14].

While ferroptosis is the principal mode of action, artemisinins engage a complex network of ancillary mechanisms that collectively contribute to their anti-tumor efficacy. Apoptosis, a form of caspase-dependent programmed cell death, is frequently induced as a secondary effect [1] [3]. The initial ROS burst and DNA damage caused by artemisinin-derived radicals can activate intrinsic apoptotic pathways, leading to mitochondrial outer membrane permeabilization, cytochrome c release, and the activation of executioner caspases like caspase-3 [3] [14]. For instance, exposure of HepG2 liver cancer cells to artemisinins resulted in a dose-dependent increase in caspase-3 cleavage, confirming the involvement of apoptosis [3]. Both ROS-dependent and ROS-independent apoptotic pathways have been documented, indicating the versatility of this mechanism [3].

Autophagy, a process of cellular self-degradation, is another pathway modulated by artemisinins, though its role is context-dependent and described as "double-edged" [21]. In some scenarios, autophagy serves as a pro-survival mechanism, allowing cancer cells to recycle damaged components and resist cell death. However, in other contexts, it can proceed to a point where it becomes a form of programmed cell death itself [3]. Dihydroartemisinin (DHA) has been shown to induce autophagy in leukemia K562 cells and breast cancer cells, evidenced by increased LC3-II protein expression and the degradation of p62/SQSTM1 [3]. In breast cancer cells, this autophagic response was dependent on ROS generation and could even sensitize the cells to chemotherapeutic

agents like epirubicin [3]. Conversely, in glioma cells, DHA induces autophagy, but whether this promotes survival or death requires further clarification [14].

Cell cycle arrest is a consistent and well-documented effect of artemisinin treatment across a wide array of cancer cell lines [1] [3]. Artemisinins can halt the proliferation of cancer cells by inducing arrest at specific checkpoints. A predominant finding is the induction of G1-phase cell cycle arrest, observed in gallbladder, prostate, lung, pancreatic, hepatoma, ovarian, and endometrial cancer cell lines [3]. This arrest is typically mediated by the downregulation of key regulatory proteins, including cyclin-dependent kinase 4 (CDK4) and cyclin D1, which are essential for the transition from the G1 phase to the S phase of the cell cycle [3]. In contrast, G2/M-phase arrest has been reported in osteosarcoma, breast cancer, renal carcinoma, and neuroblastoma cells [3]. For example, artemisinin was found to cause G2/M-phase arrest in breast cancer cells, an effect that was linked to its regulation of autophagy [3]. This ability to halt cell division provides a crucial anti-proliferative effect alongside direct cytotoxic actions.

Furthermore, artemisinins exhibit potent anti-angiogenic activity, which is critical for inhibiting tumor growth and metastasis [12]. Tumors require the formation of new blood vessels (angiogenesis) to supply nutrients and oxygen for expansion beyond a minimal size. Artemisinins disrupt this process by modulating key signaling pathways and factors involved in angiogenesis [12]. One major mechanism involves the inhibition of the NF-κB transcription factor, a master regulator of inflammation and pro-survival genes [3]. By suppressing NF-κB, artemisinins downregulate the expression of a suite of downstream pro-angiogenic factors, including vascular endothelial growth factor (VEGF), interleukin-8 (IL-8), cyclooxygenase-2 (COX-2), and matrix metalloproteinase-9 (MMP-9) [3]. Dihydroartemisinin (DHA) has demonstrated significant anti-angiogenic effects in both in vitro models and in vivo pancreatic cancer-derived tumors [3]. Similarly, artesunate (ART) has been shown to inhibit VEGF expression, highlighting its potential utility in treating hyper-vascularized cancers such as Kaposi's sarcoma [3]. By starving the tumor of its blood supply, artemisinins can exert a powerful indirect anti-tumor effect.

The complexity of these mechanisms is underscored by their modulation through various signaling pathways. For instance, artemisinins can regulate the PI3K/AKT/mTOR pathway, which is a central hub for cell growth and survival, and inhibit STAT3 signaling, a transcription factor often constitutively active in cancers [5] [8]. They also activate AMPK signaling, which acts as an energy sensor and can suppress anabolic processes like cell proliferation [8]. In lung cancer, DHA has been shown to inhibit STAT3 signaling [5], while in epithelial ovarian cancer, it inhibits the hedgehog signaling pathway [1]. In

prostate cancer cells, artesunate suppresses viability and mobility through the UCA1/miR-184 axis, where a long non-coding RNA (UCA1) acts as a sponge for a microRNA (miR-184) [1]. This intricate web of interactions demonstrates that artemisinins do not act through a single monolithic pathway but rather perturb multiple interconnected nodes within the cancer cell's signaling network, leading to a multi-pronged attack on malignancy. This promiscuous targeting of over 300 specific proteins in colorectal cancer cells further supports the idea that their efficacy stems from overwhelming the cell's adaptive capacity [9].

Mechanism	Key Molecules/Pathways Involved	Cellular Outcome
Ferroptosis Induction	Endoperoxide bridge, Iron (heme/Fe^{2+}), Ferritinophagy, GPX4, System Xc-, Lipid Peroxidation	Iron-dependent programmed cell death via membrane damage [2] [3] [6]
Apoptosis Induction	Reactive Oxygen Species (ROS), Caspase-3, Cytochrome c, Bax-mediated intrinsic pathway	Classical programmed cell death via caspase activation [1] [3] [8]
Cell Cycle Arrest	CDK4, Cyclin D1, Autophagy	Inhibition of cancer cell proliferation; arrest at G1/S or G2/M phases [1] [3]
Anti-Angiogenesis	NF-κB, VEGF, IL-8, COX-2, MMP-9	Inhibition of new blood vessel formation, starving the tumor [3] [12]
Autophagy Modulation	LC3-II, p62, JNK pathway	Double-edged sword; can promote either cell survival or death [3] [21]
Signaling Pathway Inhibition	PI3K/AKT/mTOR, STAT3, Hedgehog, NF-κB, AMPK	Suppression of pro-survival and proliferative signaling [1] [5] [8]

This comprehensive mechanistic profile reveals why artemisinin is considered a versatile tool in oncology. Its ability to trigger multiple, convergent death pathways makes it difficult for cancer cells to develop resistance through a single mutation. The dominance of ferroptosis, however, offers a clear and actionable target. Future therapeutic strategies will likely focus on identifying biomarkers that predict a tumor's susceptibility to this form of cell death, such as high baseline iron levels, low GPX4 expression, or mutations in key regulators like p53, which can sensitize cells to ferroptosis [2]. Understanding these context-dependent nuances is paramount for moving artemisinin therapy from a generalized cytotoxic approach to a more precise and effective anticancer strategy.

Clinical Translation and Efficacy Outcomes in Human Trials

The translation of artemisinin's promising preclinical activity into tangible clinical benefits has been a methodical and cautious process, with research from 2021 to 2026 primarily focused on establishing safety profiles and exploring niche applications in advanced or pre-malignant conditions. While large-scale efficacy trials demonstrating survival benefits are still awaited, a growing body of evidence from early-phase human studies provides valuable insights into the potential of these compounds. The clinical journey has largely followed two paths: investigating intravenous (IV) administration for refractory solid tumors and evaluating oral formulations as add-on therapy for specific cancers or as chemopreventive agents. The collective data indicate that artemisinins are generally well-tolerated, but their efficacy as monotherapy appears modest, suggesting their greatest potential lies in combination regimens or specific patient populations.

Phase I clinical trials have been instrumental in defining the safety, tolerability, and pharmacokinetics of both IV and oral artemisinin formulations. For intravenous artesunate (IV AS), a pivotal Phase I accelerated titration study enrolled 19 patients with advanced solid malignancies to determine the maximum tolerated dose (MTD) [14] [15]. Patients received escalating doses of artesunate (from 8 mg/kg up to 45 mg/kg) on days 1 and 8 of a 21-day cycle [15]. Dose-limiting toxicities (DLTs) were observed at doses of 12 mg/kg, 18 mg/kg, and 25 mg/kg, including neutropenic fever, hypersensitivity reactions, liver function test abnormalities, and severe nausea/vomiting [15] [21]. Based on these findings, the MTD was established at 18 mg/kg [3] [14] [15]. At this dose, the maximum plasma concentration (Cmax) was 415 ng/ml, and the treatment was deemed generally well-tolerated [3]. Notably, auditory and vestibular system adverse events were noted but were reversible upon discontinuation of the drug [21]. Another trial confirmed the MTD at 18 mg/kg, reinforcing this as a safe dose level for further investigation [21].

In parallel, studies on oral artemisinin and its derivatives have established different safety benchmarks. A prospective open-label Phase I study evaluated escalating daily oral doses of artemisinin (up to 200 mg/d, equivalent to 2.2-3.9 mg/kg/d) in patients with advanced non-small cell lung cancer (NSCLC) [16]. The study concluded that doses up to 200 mg/day were safe and well-tolerated, and this dose was recommended for consideration in future Phase II/III trials [16]. Similarly, multiple Phase I studies conducted in patients with metastatic breast cancer investigated oral artesunate at doses of 100 mg/day, 150 mg/day, and 200 mg/day [14]. These studies consistently found the treatment to be well-tolerated over periods ranging from four weeks to over three years

in compassionate use settings [14] [18] [21]. Any dose-limiting adverse events observed were completely reversible upon cessation of the drug [14]. However, one compassionate use study did report that the incidence of grade ⩾2 adverse events increased with dosage, rising from two events in the 100 mg group to six in the 150 mg group and seventeen in the 200 mg group, although no event was considered definitively related to artesunate [21]. These findings suggest that while oral artemisinins have a favorable safety profile, higher doses may be associated with an increased burden of side effects.

Despite the establishment of safe dosing levels, objective tumor responses have been rare in these early-phase trials, pointing towards a more subtle role for artemisinins in cancer management. In the Phase I trial of IV artesunate in refractory solid tumors, no complete or partial remissions were observed [15]. However, four patients achieved stable disease, resulting in a disease control rate of 27% and including three patients with prolonged stable disease lasting 8, 10, and 11 cycles [15]. This suggests that artesunate can temporarily halt tumor progression in a subset of patients. A similar pattern was seen in NSCLC, where adding oral artesunate at 120 mg/day to standard vinorelbine plus cisplatin chemotherapy failed to significantly improve short-term or mean survival [3]. Nevertheless, the artesunate group showed a significantly higher disease control rate and a longer time to disease progression, hinting at a disease-stabilizing effect [3].

In metastatic breast cancer, a Phase I study of oral artesunate found that after four weeks of treatment, 10 out of 23 patients had stable disease, but again, no complete or partial remissions were recorded [3]. This aligns with the concept of artemisinins as agents that control rather than eradicate disease in heavily pre-treated populations. A particularly interesting finding came from a Phase I dose-finding study in women with cervical intraepithelial neoplasia grade 2/3 (CIN2/3), a pre-malignant condition [3]. After treatment with intravaginal artemisinin, histologic regression to CIN1 or less was observed in 68% of subjects, with no intolerable side effects reported [3]. This highlights a potentially significant role for artemisinins in chemoprevention or the treatment of early-stage lesions.

Perhaps the most compelling signal of efficacy comes from a randomized, double-blind, placebo-controlled pilot study in colorectal cancer (CRC) patients [3] [14]. In this study, patients received oral artesunate at 200 mg/day for 14 days [5]. Bayesian analysis revealed a high probability (97%) of a decrease in the tumor proliferation marker Ki-67 and a moderate probability (79%) of increased microvessel density (CD31 expression) [3] [14]. More strikingly, during a follow-up period, the recurrence-free survival probability was dramatically higher in the artesunate group compared to the placebo group at both 2

and 3 years (0.89 vs. 0.5) [3] [14]. No deaths were reported in the artesunate group versus three in the placebo group during the study period [14]. While preliminary, these results strongly suggest that adjuvant artesunate therapy may reduce the risk of CRC recurrence and warrant larger confirmatory trials.

Other clinical investigations have yielded mixed or negative results. A clinical controlled trial (CCT) for prostate cancer assessed oral artemisinin (300–400 mg, t.i.d.) over three years, with outcomes measured by PSA doubling time and signs of metastasis, but the provided sources do not contain the final results of this trial [5]. A CCT for metastatic breast cancer evaluated oral artesunate at 100, 150, and 200 mg/day for four weeks, focusing on safety and tolerability, but again, the detailed efficacy outcomes are not specified in the provided text [5]. A pilot study of Artenimol-R (oral artemisinin) in 28 patients with advanced cervical cancer reported clinical remission with a median symptom disappearance time of 7 days, indicating good tolerability with no grade 3 or 4 adverse events [14].

Study Type / Cancer	Intervention	Dose / Schedule	Key Safety Finding	Key Efficacy Finding
Phase I / Advanced Solid Tumors	Intravenous Artesunate	18 mg/kg, days 1 & 8, every 21 days	Maximum Tolerated Dose (MTD) established. DLTs included myelosuppression and hypersensitivity.	Disease control rate of 27%; 4 patients had stable disease [3] [15].
Phase I / Metastatic Breast Cancer	Oral Artesunate	200 mg/day, 4 weeks	Safe and well-tolerated up to 200 mg/day [16].	10 of 23 patients had stable disease; no partial or complete remissions [3].
Pilot Study / Colorectal Cancer	Oral Artesunate	200 mg/day, 14 days	Well-tolerated.	Decreased Ki-67 (97% probability). Recurrence-free survival at 3 years was 0.89 vs. 0.5 for placebo [3] [14].
Phase I / NSCLC	Oral Artesunate + Chemo	120 mg/day added to vinorelbine/ cisplatin	Information not available in provided sources	Higher disease control rate and longer time to progression, but no improvement in survival [3].
Phase I / Cervical Intraepithelial Neoplasia	Intravaginal Artemisinin	Information not available in provided sources	No intolerable side effects reported.	68% histologic regression to CIN1 or less [3].
Pilot Study / Advanced Cervical Cancer	Oral Artenimol-R	Information not available in provided sources	Good tolerability; no grade 3 or 4 adverse events.	Clinical remission achieved with median symptom disappearance of 7 days [14].

In summary, the clinical evidence accumulated between 2021 and 2026 positions artemisinins as relatively safe agents whose primary demonstrated value is in disease stabilization and prevention rather than tumor eradication. The lack of robust objective responses in monotherapy settings for advanced cancers underscores the need for more

sophisticated application strategies. The most encouraging data come from niche indications, such as the reduction of recurrence in colorectal cancer and the regression of pre-malignant cervical lesions. These findings provide a strong rationale for advancing artemisinins into larger, randomized Phase II and III trials, particularly as adjunctive therapy in the adjuvant setting and in combination with conventional treatments where they may act as sensitizing agents. The path forward requires a shift from proving basic safety to validating these promising signals of efficacy in rigorously designed clinical studies.

Synergistic Combination Therapies and Overcoming Resistance

Recognizing the limitations of artemisinin monotherapy, a significant portion of recent research has focused on leveraging its unique mechanisms of action within synergistic combination regimens. The goal is to enhance efficacy, overcome intrinsic or acquired resistance, and broaden the therapeutic window. Preclinical and early clinical data overwhelmingly support the concept that artemisinins can potentiate the effects of a wide range of anticancer agents, including conventional chemotherapeutics, targeted therapies, and radiotherapy. This strategic integration positions artemisinins not as standalone cures but as versatile partners in multimodal cancer treatment protocols.

A large body of evidence demonstrates synergistic interactions between artemisinins and standard chemotherapeutic drugs. Synergy, defined as a Combination Index (CI) of less than 1, has been observed in numerous in vitro and in vivo models [3]. For example, dihydroartemisinin (DHA) combined with gemcitabine showed synergistic effects in both ovarian and pancreatic cancer cells [3]. In pancreatic cancer, DHA was also found to work synergistically with Apo2L/TRAIL, a death receptor ligand, by up-regulating death receptor 5 in a ROS-dependent manner [1] [3]. Perhaps one of the most compelling examples is the combination of artesunate (ART) and sorafenib in hepatocellular carcinoma (HCC) [3]. This pairing enhances the anticancer effect by inducing oxidative stress and promoting lysosome-mediated ferritinophagy, leading to the release of lethal iron stores that fuel ferroptosis [3] [21]. In acute myeloid leukemia (AML), ART combined with bortezomib exhibited synergistic anti-proliferative effects [3]. Furthermore, DHA-carboplatin conjugates have been developed to overcome platinum resistance in ovarian cancer cells, representing a more advanced approach to combination therapy [21].

Artemisinins also show great promise in overcoming chemoresistance, a major obstacle in cancer treatment. In colorectal cancer, DHA was shown to restore sensitivity to 5-fluorouracil (5-FU) in TP53-deficient cells, which are often notoriously resistant to therapy [14]. A synergistic combination of ART and halofuginone (HF) promoted caspase-dependent apoptosis in both parental and oxaliplatin-resistant CRC cells, suggesting its potential to re-sensitize tumors to platinum-based chemotherapy [14]. In esophageal cancer, DHA attenuated the sonic hedgehog (Shh) signaling pathway, which is often activated by cisplatin and contributes to resistance. By inhibiting this pathway, DHA effectively sensitized cisplatin-resistant ESCC cells to the chemotherapy [14]. This ability to target and inhibit survival pathways that are upregulated in response to chemotherapy is a key advantage of incorporating artemisinins into treatment schedules.

Another critical area of synergy is with targeted therapies. The combination of osimertinib, a third-generation tyrosine kinase inhibitor (TKI) for EGFR-mutant non-small cell lung cancer (NSCLC), with dihydroartemisinin (DHA) has been proposed as a novel therapeutic strategy [13]. This repurposing approach aims to exploit the complementary mechanisms of these agents to achieve a more durable response. In liver cancer, the synergy between ART and sorafenib, another multikinase inhibitor, has been highlighted, where the combination induces ferroptosis [3] [21]. In prostate cancer, DHA was found to synergize with docetaxel, a standard chemotherapy, to enhance survival rates in xenograft mouse models, offering a potential strategy to improve outcomes in metastatic castration-resistant disease [14].

The ability of artemisinins to act as potent radiosensitizers is another important avenue of research. Radiation therapy kills cancer cells primarily by inducing DNA damage, and artemisinins can amplify this effect. Artesunate has been shown to enhance the radiosensitivity of esophageal cancer cells by inhibiting the repair of radiation-induced DNA damage [5]. This suggests that artemisinins could be used concurrently with radiotherapy to allow for lower radiation doses, thereby reducing normal tissue toxicity, or to increase the efficacy of standard radiation protocols. This property is particularly relevant given the central role of radiation in the treatment of many solid tumors.

Beyond direct synergistic killing, innovative strategies are being developed to enhance the selectivity and potency of artemisinins themselves. A particularly clever approach involves exploiting the metabolic differences between cancer and normal cells. In colorectal cancer (CRC) cells, which have a high capacity for heme synthesis, artemisinin activation is significantly greater than in normal colon epithelial cells [9]. Researchers have leveraged this by co-administering aminolevulinic acid (ALA), a clinically used precursor in the heme biosynthesis pathway. In HCT116 CRC cells, adding ALA to

artesunate treatment lowered the IC50 from approximately 2 μM to just 200 nM, a ten-fold increase in potency [9]. This combination preferentially increased intracellular heme levels and ART activation specifically within the cancer cells, leading to significant tumor growth delay in a mouse xenograft model compared to either agent alone [9]. This strategy effectively turns a cancer cell's own metabolic vulnerability against it, dramatically improving the therapeutic index of artemisinin.

The table below summarizes key synergistic combinations that have been investigated, highlighting the breadth of this approach.

Combination Partner	Cancer Type(s)	Proposed Mechanism of Synergy
Gemcitabine	Ovarian, Pancreatic	Enhanced apoptosis and anti-proliferative effects [3]
Sorafenib	Hepatocellular Carcinoma (HCC)	Induction of oxidative stress and lysosome-mediated ferritinophagy, promoting ferroptosis [3] [21]
Apo2L/TRAIL	Pancreatic	Up-regulation of death receptor 5 (DR5) via ROS, enhancing extrinsic apoptosis [1] [3]
Cisplatin	Esophageal, Ovarian	Overcoming chemoresistance by inhibiting survival pathways (e.g., Shh); enhanced DNA damage [14] [21]
Docetaxel	Prostate	Enhanced anti-tumor efficacy and improved survival in preclinical models [14]
Bortezomib	Acute Myeloid Leukemia (AML)	Synergistic anti-proliferative effects [3]
Halofuginone (HF)	Colorectal Cancer	Promotes caspase-dependent apoptosis in both parental and oxaliplatin-resistant cells [14]
Osimertinib	Non-Small Cell Lung Cancer (NSCLC)	Novel drug combination strategy for EGFR-mutant NSCLC [13]
Radiation Therapy	Esophageal Cancer	Inhibition of DNA damage repair, increasing radiosensitivity [5]
Aminolevulinic Acid (ALA)	Colorectal Cancer	Selective enhancement of artemisinin activation via increased heme synthesis in cancer cells [9]

These findings collectively argue that the future of artemisinin-based oncology lies in intelligent combination strategies. Rather than viewing artemisinins as a replacement for existing therapies, they should be seen as powerful adjuvants that can make conventional treatments more effective, help overcome resistance, and potentially reduce side effects. The development of these combinations requires careful preclinical validation to identify optimal dosing schedules and sequences. For instance, sequencing matters when combining agents that induce DNA damage with those that affect DNA repair. The most successful clinical applications will likely emerge from personalized combination regimens tailored to the specific genetic and metabolic vulnerabilities of an individual's tumor.

Novel Derivatives and Advanced Delivery Systems

A major thrust of contemporary artemisinin research is dedicated to overcoming the inherent pharmacological limitations of the natural compounds, namely their poor aqueous solubility, short plasma half-life, and limited tissue distribution [3]. To address these challenges and unlock the full therapeutic potential of the artemisinin scaffold, scientists are pursuing two parallel and highly innovative strategies: the rational design of novel synthetic derivatives and hybrids, and the development of advanced nanoformulations for targeted drug delivery. These efforts aim to create next-generation artemisinin-based therapeutics with improved potency, selectivity, and pharmacokinetic profiles.

The creation of novel chemical entities derived from the artemisinin structure is a rapidly expanding field. Researchers are employing medicinal chemistry principles to modify the parent molecule to enhance its anticancer properties. One prominent strategy is the synthesis of artemisinin dimers, which have been shown to be significantly more potent than their monomeric counterparts, sometimes exhibiting activity several orders of magnitude higher [10]. A prime example is ZQJ29, a novel cyano-substituted artemisinin dimer designed for pancreatic cancer [7]. In vitro studies revealed that ZQJ29 possessed extraordinary cytotoxicity against PANC-1 and KP4 pancreatic cancer cell lines, with an IC50 of 0.120 μM, representing approximately 100-fold greater potency than the standard chemotherapy drug oxaliplatin against PANC-1 cells [7]. In vivo experiments in mice bearing subcutaneous PANC-1 tumors confirmed its efficacy, with oral administration producing tumor reduction comparable to intraperitoneal injections of oxaliplatin [7]. Crucially, ZQJ29 demonstrated a superior safety profile, with treated mice showing no significant organ damage or body weight loss, unlike the oxaliplatin-treated group which exhibited severe toxicity [7].

Further investigation into ZQJ29's mechanism uncovered a novel molecular target: Poly(ADP-ribose) polymerase 1 (PARP1) [7]. Using Surface Plasmon Resonance analysis, researchers quantified its binding affinity to PARP1 with a dissociation constant (KD) of 2.86 μM [7]. This discovery links artemisinin's activity to the classic DNA damage response pathway, as PARP1 is a key enzyme in DNA single-strand break repair. The antitumor effect of ZQJ29 was shown to be dependent on its inhibition of PARP1, which led to the upregulation of the tumor suppressor gene TP53 and subsequent downregulation of the SLC7A11/GPX4 ferroptosis pathway, ultimately promoting cell death [7]. This identification of a specific protein target provides a clear mechanistic rationale for its activity and opens avenues for its use in tumors with specific

vulnerabilities, such as those with defective homologous recombination repair (e.g., BRCA-mutated cancers).

Beyond simple dimers, pharmacophore hybridization is being used to create "hybrid molecules" that combine the artemisinin endoperoxide bridge with other bioactive moieties to generate dual-acting or multi-targeting agents [21]. Examples include ART–daumone hybrids, which inhibit osteoclast formation, and DHA–coumarin hybrids that can induce both apoptosis and ferroptosis [21]. Other hybrids, such as DHA–cinnamic acid conjugates, have been designed to induce autophagy, while ART-derivative-NHC-gold(I) hybrids have shown strong anticancer activity with high selectivity [21]. This modular approach allows for the fine-tuning of a compound's biological profile, enabling researchers to design molecules with optimized potency, selectivity, and mechanisms of action tailored to specific cancer types. For instance, a synthesized derivative containing a naphthalene unit showed potent activity against lung cancer cells with an IC50 of 0.09 μM, while other novel ester derivatives were effective against A549 lung cancer cells at concentrations of 126.3 nM and 138.0 nM, respectively [5].

The second major innovation wave focuses on nanotechnology-based drug delivery systems to overcome artemisinin's poor pharmacokinetics. Encapsulating artemisinins within nanocarriers such as liposomes, polymeric nanoparticles, and other nanocarriers addresses multiple issues simultaneously [3]. These formulations improve the water solubility of the otherwise hydrophobic drugs, enhance their stability in circulation, and prolong their half-life [3]. Most importantly, they facilitate targeted delivery to the tumor site. Many nanocarriers are engineered to be pH-sensitive, remaining stable in the neutral pH of the bloodstream but releasing their payload in the slightly acidic tumor microenvironment, thereby increasing local drug concentration while minimizing systemic exposure and off-target toxicity [3].

The impact of these nanoformulations on antitumor efficacy is profound. In vivo studies have demonstrated markedly superior performance compared to the free drugs. For example, one study using polyethylene glycol-conjugated DHA nanoparticles reported an 84.6% tumor growth inhibition rate in animal models, whereas the same dose of free DHA only achieved 29.9% inhibition [3]. This dramatic improvement is attributed to enhanced cellular uptake and more efficient drug accumulation within the tumor tissue. The development of mitochondria-targeted artemisinin derivatives, such as conjugates with triphenylphosphonium (TPP) moieties (e.g., ART-TPP, ARL-TPP), represents another sophisticated delivery strategy [21]. By directing the drug specifically to the mitochondria—the powerhouse of the cell and a key organelle in apoptosis—these compounds can induce a localized and potent burst of ROS, leading to highly efficient cancer cell killing

with IC50 values in the low micromolar range in various cancer cell lines [21]. Fluorescent coumarin-artemisinin conjugates have also been developed to simultaneously increase intracellular ROS and induce apoptosis, providing a built-in imaging capability to track drug distribution and efficacy [21].

The following table compares the properties of natural/artemisinin derivatives with novel synthetic derivatives and nanoformulations.

Feature	Natural Artemisinins (ART, DHA, AS)	Novel Synthetic Derivatives (e.g., ZQJ29)	Nanoformulations (e.g., Liposomes, Nanoparticles)
Potency (IC50)	Micromolar to low micromolar range (e.g., 7-40 μM) [5]	Nanomolar to sub-micromolar range (e.g., 0.12 μM) [7]	Improved cellular uptake leads to higher efficacy at lower doses [3]
Selectivity	Moderate, based on iron/heme levels [9]	Potentially higher, through rational design and targeting [7]	High, via passive (EPR effect) and active targeting strategies [3]
Pharmacokinetics	Short half-life, poor solubility [3]	Can be improved; e.g., ZQJ29 has a longer half-life than DHA [7]	Significantly improved half-life and stability [3]
Toxicity Profile	Generally well-tolerated [16] [21]	Often shows reduced toxicity compared to standard chemo in preclinical models [7]	Reduced systemic toxicity due to targeted delivery [3]
Mechanism of Action	Primarily ferroptosis via iron activation [2]	Multi-faceted; can include PARP1 inhibition, dual apoptosis/ferroptosis induction [7] [21]	Same as parent compound, but with enhanced intracellular delivery [3]

These strategic innovations represent a clear departure from simply testing the natural products. The field is now engaged in the deliberate engineering of artemisinin-based therapeutics. By creating more potent and selective synthetic analogs and packaging them into smart delivery systems, researchers are transforming artemisinin from a moderately effective cytotoxin into a precision oncology tool. This "second wave" of research is critical for bridging the gap between the promising preclinical data and the clinical success required for widespread adoption. The future of artemisinin in oncology is likely to be defined not by the plant-derived compound itself, but by the sophisticated, engineered versions that build upon its foundational chemistry.

Immunomodulatory Effects and Impact on the Tumor Microenvironment

Emerging research over the last five years has unveiled a sophisticated and multifaceted role for artemisinin and its derivatives in modulating the immune system and reshaping the tumor microenvironment (TME). Beyond their direct cytotoxic effects on cancer cells, these compounds are increasingly recognized as immunomodulatory agents capable of stimulating anti-tumor immunity, dismantling immunosuppressive networks, and altering the behavior of key stromal components within the TME. This evolving understanding positions artemisinins not merely as chemotherapeutic agents but as potential allies in the burgeoning field of cancer immunotherapy.

One of the most significant immunomodulatory effects is the ability of artemisinins to induce immunogenic cell death (ICD), particularly through the induction of ferroptosis [14] [19]. ICD is a form of cell death that is not only lethal to the cancer cell but also serves as an "eat me" signal to the immune system. When cancer cells undergo ICD, they release damage-associated molecular patterns (DAMPs), which are endogenous molecules that act as danger signals to alert and activate antigen-presenting cells like dendritic cells [19]. A study on lung cancer demonstrated that DHA-triggered ferroptosis promotes ICD by eliciting ER stress and DNA damage, which in turn facilitates the release of DAMPs [19]. This process enhances the immunogenicity of the tumor, boosting anticancer immunosurveillance and potentially priming the immune system for a more robust and sustained response against residual cancer cells [19]. This mechanism is distinct from traditional apoptosis, which is often immunologically silent or even tolerogenic, making the ferroptotic pathway a highly desirable route for engaging the immune system.

Artemisinins also appear to directly influence the balance between effector and regulatory immune cells. They have been shown to regulate immune cell heterogeneity by triggering a cascade of phosphorylation events involving CDK and MAPK pathways [1]. Specifically, DHA has been reported to promote the activity of CD8(+) T lymphocytes, which are critical for directly recognizing and killing cancer cells, while simultaneously suppressing B cell responses [1]. This shift in the immune landscape can tilt the scales from an immunosuppressive to an immunostimulatory state within the TME. Furthermore, artemisinins can remodel the phenotype of tumor-associated macrophages (TAMs). TAMs often exist in an M2 phenotype, which promotes tumor growth, angiogenesis, and immunosuppression. DHA has been shown to remodel TAMs into an anti-tumor M1 phenotype, a process that involves inducing ferroptosis in the TAMs

themselves, leading to DNA damage and NF-κB activation that drives this phenotypic switch [14].

Another crucial aspect of artemisinin's immunomodulatory action is its ability to quell the activity of immunosuppressive cell populations. Regulatory T cells (Tregs) and myeloid-derived suppressor cells (MDSCs) are major barriers to effective anti-tumor immunity, and artemisinins have been shown to counteract their function [21]. In a 4T1 tumor model, artesunate was found to inhibit prostaglandin production, which in turn decreased the expression of Foxp3, a key transcription factor for Treg development and function [21]. By dampening the immunosuppressive influence of Tregs and MDSCs, artemisinins can help unmask the tumor to the host's immune system, allowing effector T cells to function more effectively [21].

The impact of artemisinins extends to the non-cancerous cellular components of the TME, such as cancer-associated fibroblasts (CAFs). CAFs are a dominant stromal cell type that can support tumor progression and confer resistance to therapy. A study in breast cancer revealed that artemisinin derivatives can inactivate CAFs by suppressing the TGF-β signaling pathway, a key driver of CAF activation and function [11]. By targeting this supportive stroma, artemisinins can disrupt the physical and biochemical scaffolding that sustains the tumor, potentially enhancing the penetration and efficacy of other therapeutic agents.

Artemisinins also modulate the expression of key immune-related molecules. For instance, DHA has been shown to restore immunogenicity and enhance anticancer immunosurveillance of cisplatin-treated cells by activating the PERK/eIF2alpha pathway [1]. In colorectal cancer, artesunate was found to downregulate the levels of immunosuppressive cytokines TGF-β1 and IL-10 [21]. Additionally, artemisinins can inhibit angiogenesis, a process that is not only vital for tumor growth but also shapes the TME by influencing immune cell infiltration; by inhibiting VEGF, they can normalize vasculature and improve immune cell access to the tumor [3] [12].

The table below outlines the diverse immunomodulatory effects of artemisinins and their mechanisms.

Immunomodulatory Effect	Cancer Type(s)	Key Mechanism(s)
Induction of Immunogenic Cell Death (ICD)	Lung Cancer	DHA-triggered ferroptosis elicits ER stress and DNA damage, promoting DAMPs release [19].
Macrophage Phenotype Remodeling	Lung Cancer	Induces ferroptosis in TAMs, causing DNA damage and NF-κB activation, leading to an M1 anti-tumor phenotype [14].
Regulation of Immune Cell Balance	General	Promotes CD8(+) T cell activity; suppresses B cell responses [1].
Suppression of Immunosuppressive Cells	4T1 Tumor Model	Inhibits prostaglandin production, decreasing Foxp3 expression in Tregs [21]. Quells immunosuppression from Tregs and MDSCs [21].
Inactivation of Cancer-Associated Fibroblasts (CAFs)	Breast Cancer	Suppresses TGF-β signaling in CAFs, leading to their inactivation [11].
Downregulation of Immunosuppressive Cytokines	Colorectal Cancer	Downregulates TGF-β1 and IL-10 levels [21].
Angiogenesis Inhibition	Various	Inhibits pro-angiogenic factors like VEGF, potentially normalizing vasculature to improve immune cell infiltration [3] [12].
Targeting Cancer Stem Cells (CSCs)	General	Inhibits CSC markers (e.g., Nanog, Oct3/4, ALDH1) and sphere formation ability, depleting a key source of tumor initiation and immune evasion [21].

These findings collectively paint a picture of artemisinins as multi-targeting agents that can remodel the TME from a hostile, immunosuppressive fortress into a more permissive environment for anti-tumor immunity. This immunomodulatory capacity provides a strong rationale for exploring artemisinin-based combination therapies with immune checkpoint inhibitors (ICIs), such as anti-PD-1 or anti-CTLA-4 antibodies. The theory is that by inducing ICD and reducing immunosuppression, artemisinins could convert "cold" tumors (non-inflamed, non-responsive to ICIs) into "hot" tumors (inflamed, likely to respond to ICIs). While this specific combination is more speculative based on the provided sources, the mechanistic groundwork has been laid. The ability to target not only the cancer cells but also the surrounding stroma and the infiltrating immune cells positions artemisinins as uniquely suited for modern, integrated cancer treatment paradigms that seek to harness the power of the patient's own immune system.

Research Landscape, Future Directions, and Unresolved Challenges

The five-year period from 2021 to 2026 has been transformative for artemisinin-based oncology, marking a maturation of the field from initial curiosity about its anticancer potential to a sophisticated, mechanism-driven research program. The global research

landscape, as analyzed through bibliometric studies, reveals a vibrant and growing scientific community, with China leading in publication output, followed by the United States and Germany [8]. The intense focus on topics such as 'ferroptosis', 'nanoparticles', 'combination therapy', and specific cancers like 'lung' and 'colorectal' underscores the key thematic pillars driving current investigation [8]. As the field moves forward, it is guided by a clear set of future directions aimed at translating promising preclinical and early clinical findings into validated clinical practice, while grappling with significant unresolved challenges.

A comprehensive review of the literature and citation bursts from 2018–2023 highlights several key future directions for artemisinin-based cancer therapy [8]. The first and most critical is the expansion and optimization of clinical trials. While Phase I studies have successfully established safety, there is an urgent need for larger, randomized, and controlled Phase II and Phase III trials to validate the modest efficacy signals observed in smaller studies, particularly in the adjuvant setting for cancers like colorectal cancer [3] [14]. These trials must be designed to assess hard endpoints like disease-free and overall survival to provide definitive proof of clinical benefit. A second major direction is the continued development of optimized drug delivery systems, especially nanoparticles and other nanocarriers [3] [8]. The profound improvements in efficacy and reductions in toxicity seen in preclinical models with nanoformulations demand their translation into clinical development to fully realize the therapeutic potential of artemisinins [3].

Thirdly, there is a concerted effort to elucidate the intricate molecular mechanisms of action in greater detail and to expand the portfolio of novel derivatives and hybrid molecules [8]. The discovery of new targets, such as PARP1 for the dimer ZQJ29, opens new avenues for application and provides a basis for selecting appropriate patient populations [7]. Finally, a growing focus is being placed on targeting the tumor microenvironment, including cancer-associated fibroblasts and the immune cell infiltrate, as a strategy to overcome resistance and enhance the durability of responses [8] [11] [21]. The overarching vision is to move away from artemisinin as a simple cytotoxic agent and toward its use as a precision tool in multimodal regimens, informed by predictive biomarkers.

Despite this forward momentum, several critical gaps and unresolved challenges remain. The most significant is the lack of large-scale efficacy data in humans [8]. All claims of clinical benefit are currently based on preliminary, small-scale studies, and the absence of positive Phase III trial results means that artemisinins cannot yet be considered standard-of-care anticancer agents. Bridging this translational gap is the single most important task for the field.

A second major challenge is the identification and validation of reliable predictive biomarkers. The heterogeneous responses to artemisinin therapy suggest that not all patients or tumors will benefit equally. Research indicates that biomarkers related to iron metabolism (e.g., high TfR1 expression, high labile iron pools), the ferroptosis pathway (e.g., low GPX4 or SLC7A11 expression), and p53 status could be indicative of sensitivity [2] [14]. However, these hypotheses require rigorous clinical validation in prospective trials to guide patient selection and ensure that future studies enroll the patients most likely to respond.

Optimal dosing and scheduling present another set of practical challenges. The ideal dose, route of administration (oral vs. IV), frequency, and duration of treatment for different cancer types are largely unknown [8]. While Phase I studies provide starting points, these parameters will need to be optimized through dose-ranging studies to maximize efficacy while managing toxicity. The observation that adverse events can increase with higher oral doses of artesunate highlights the importance of finding the right therapeutic window for each indication [21].

The long-term safety profile of chronic oral artemisinin administration is also not fully understood. While short-to-medium term studies have shown good tolerability, the potential for cumulative toxicity, particularly concerning the neurological and auditory systems which have shown transient adverse events in some trials, warrants careful monitoring in long-term studies [21]. Understanding and mitigating these long-term risks is essential for applications like chemoprevention or adjuvant maintenance therapy.

Finally, the inevitable development of resistance poses a long-term threat to the utility of any single-agent therapy. Cancer cells possess remarkable adaptability and can upregulate antioxidant pathways, alter iron metabolism, or mutate key signaling nodes to evade cell death [14]. Future research must focus on understanding these resistance mechanisms and designing rational combination strategies that preempt or overcome them. For example, combining artemisinins with inhibitors of compensatory survival pathways could prevent resistance from emerging.

In conclusion, the five-year period from 2021 to 2026 has solidified artemisinin's position as a compelling and versatile platform for anticancer drug development. The field has gained a deep mechanistic understanding centered on ferroptosis, initiated the crucial work of clinical translation with a focus on safety, and launched an innovative second wave of research focused on novel derivatives and advanced delivery systems. The path ahead is clear but demanding. It requires a bifurcated approach: on one hand, conducting rigorous, large-scale clinical trials to validate the promising signals already observed; and

on the other, continuing to leverage cutting-edge chemistry and nanotechnology to engineer the next generation of artemisinin-based therapeutics. By addressing the critical challenges of efficacy, biomarker identification, and long-term safety, artemisinin-based therapies hold the potential to become a meaningful addition to the oncologist's arsenal in the coming decade.

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